

Executive Presence

Communication Frameworks Reference Guide

Version 2 · 12 Frameworks

Group	Frameworks	What it governs
Structure	BLUF · Minto Pyramid · C·D·S	How you organise what you say
Thinking	PMI · SCR · Story Structure	How you reason and frame
Interaction	Decisive Answering · Meeting Lead · A·D·A · Read Before You Respond	How you handle live exchange
Embodiment	Pause Principle · Consistency Compound	How you deliver, and what compounds

A Center for Talent Innovation survey found 89% of executives believe executive presence directly contributes to career advancement — but 81% of people told to “improve their executive presence” had no idea what to do with that feedback. These frameworks exist to make it concrete and practisable.

PART ONE

Structure

How you organise what you say

FRAMEWORK 1

Bottom Line Up Front (BLUF)

State your answer or recommendation first. Explain why second. Executives read top-down — never make them wait for your point.

✗ Before

We looked at the data, ran the analysis, considered all the options, and after everything we think maybe we should go with Option B...

✓ After

We should go with Option B. It cuts cost by 20% with acceptable risk. Here's why.

✗ Before

There were some challenges with the launch timeline and after talking to the team we realised there might be a delay...

✓ After

The launch will slip by 2 weeks. Root cause is 3 unresolved blockers in QA. Here's the recovery plan.

Key insight: If someone stopped reading after your first sentence, would they still know what you want? If no — rewrite.

FRAMEWORK 2

Minto Pyramid Principle

Structure any message so an exec can stop reading at any level and still have what they need.

Vertical logic — each point answers “Why?” from the level above. **Horizontal MECE** — points at the same level are mutually exclusive and collectively exhaustive.

Level	Content	Example
Governing thought	Your single recommendation or answer	Cloud costs jumped 40% due to 3 controllable issues — fix plan recovers 25% in 30 days.
Key arguments (×3)	MECE reasons that answer “why?”	Untagged dev envs · Misconfigured auto-scaling · No reserved instances
Supporting data	Evidence that proves each argument	~\$8K/mo waste · Triggered 8× unnecessarily · 35% savings on switch

Key insight: Write bottom-up if you need to think it through. Send top-down always.

FRAMEWORK 3

Talk With Data (C·D·S)

Numbers make claims credible. Vague language makes them dismissible.

	Element	What it means
C	Claim	Your point — the assertion you're making
D	Data	The specific number that proves it. No vague qualifiers.
S	So what	The implication or decision it drives

Vague	Precise
"The team has been a bit slow"	Velocity fell 38% over six weeks (34 → 21 story points/sprint), driven by 3 engineers out.
"We're going to be a bit late"	v2.0 ships Oct 3 — 21 days past the Sept 12 target.
"A lot of customers complained"	38 support tickets in 72 hrs — 3× our weekly average.

No exact number? Use a range — "between 15–25%" beats "quite a bit." Or anchor: "roughly 2× what we saw in Q1."

Key insight: Stop reaching for adjectives (slow, late, bad). Reach for numbers.

PART TWO

Thinking

How you reason and frame

FRAMEWORK 4

PMI (de Bono)

Use PMI to *think*. Use the Minto Pyramid to *present*. Showing you've stress-tested both sides earns trust.

Plus	Minus	Interesting
Genuine upsides — value created, problems solved. Be specific with data.	Real downsides — cost, risk, what breaks. Name the probability or cost.	Questions raised, dependencies, second-order effects. Neither good nor bad yet.

Example — hiring decision:

Plus	Minus	Interesting
Restores velocity toward v2.0 (21→34+ pts/sprint). Reduces burnout on 8-person team at 112% load.	~\$90K/mo additional burn. Runway shrinks 14→11 months. 60–90 day ramp delays gains.	Does hiring signal confidence or concern to investors? Can we hire contract first as a hedge?

Recommendation: Hire 2 now (not 3) — targeting roles that unblock v2.0. \$60K/mo buys back 12+ weeks of velocity without fully stressing runway.

Key insight: A strong Interesting column is the mark of a senior thinker. Don't leave it blank.

FRAMEWORK 5

SCR Narrative Arc

Logic convinces. Story moves people to act.

Part	Purpose
S — Situation	The stable context everyone agrees on. No tension yet.
C — Complication	The disruption. What changed, what's at risk. The “Why does this matter?” moment.
R — Resolution	What we do about it. Your BLUF recommendation, with context and urgency behind it.

x Before

We need to hire 2 engineers. Here are 3 reasons: velocity is down, the bug backlog is growing, and v2.0 is delayed.

✓ After

[S] We built a team capable of shipping every quarter. [C] Over the last six weeks, three engineers left simultaneously and velocity dropped 38%. [R] To get back on track without stressing runway, we should hire 2 senior engineers now.

The complication is the most important sentence you'll write. “Sales are up” is a situation. “Sales are up but NPS dropped 12 points — we're growing into a churn problem” is a complication.

Key insight: SCR and Minto nest — use SCR to open, Minto to structure the recommendation inside the Resolution.

FRAMEWORK 6

Story Structure

People remember stories. They forget slides.

Part	Purpose	Test
Hook	Grab attention in the first sentence	Would someone lean forward or check their phone?
Context	Set the stakes	Is there real tension — something at risk?
Insight	The thing they couldn't see before	Is this a reframe, or just restating data?
Call to action	One specific ask	Is it a decision, or vague “let's discuss”?

4 types of hook: Surprising stat · Specific moment · Provocative question · Sharp contrast

Example — enterprise pivot all-hands:

Hook: “Eighteen customers are generating more revenue than twelve hundred.”

Context: “Self-serve: 1,240 customers, 34% annual churn, competitors cutting prices 30%. Enterprise: 18 deals in six months, 6% churn, \$87K average ARR. Top 10 accounts = 58% of revenue.”

Insight: “Enterprise costs 4× more to serve — but LTV is 22× higher. We've been optimising for volume, not value.”

CTA: “Leave today with one commitment to something you'll do differently next quarter.”

Key insight: The audience is the hero — not you.

PART THREE

Interaction

How you handle live exchange

FRAMEWORK 7

Decisive Answering

Three valid answers exist. Everything else is hedging.

Answer	How to use it
Yes	State it. Say what it means or what happens next.
No	State it. Give the reason and what you'd recommend instead.
I'll find out by [time]	Own the gap. Commit to a specific time — not “soon” or “ASAP”.

Avoid: “It depends” · “That’s a good question” · “I’m not totally sure but...” · “We’ll have to see”

Example: “Should we discount 20% to close this quarter?”

“No. At 20% we’re below our floor margin on this deal tier. I’d offer 10% with extended payment terms — that closes the quarter and protects margin.”

Key insight: Credibility = saying + doing. If you commit to “I’ll find out by Thursday,” Thursday must deliver.

FRAMEWORK 8

Leading Meetings

How you open a meeting signals whether you’re running it or just attending it.

Sentence	Template
1	“We’re here to decide [specific decision].” (<i>not “discuss”</i>)
2	“My recommendation is [clear stance] — [1-line reason with data].”
3	“I want to hear your [concerns] and we need to leave with [specific outcome].”

✗ Before

“Thanks everyone for joining. So, um, we wanted to get together to talk about the pricing question and kind of hear everyone’s thoughts. Who wants to start?”

✓ After

“We’re here to decide whether to raise prices 8% in Q1. My recommendation is yes — I’ll share why in 2 minutes, then I want to hear your pushback. We need a decision by end of this call.”

Key insight: “We’re here to decide X” (not “discuss X”) — discussion is the means; the decision is the point.

FRAMEWORK 9

Handling Pushback (A·D·A)

Hold your ground without being defensive. Update without caving.

Step	What to do
A — Acknowledge	Show you heard the concern. Don't dismiss, don't immediately counter.
D — Data	Respond with evidence, not a restated opinion louder.
A — Affirm or Adjust	Restate if you still believe it. Update openly if they raised genuinely new information.

Caving	Updating
Changing position because someone pushed harder or is more senior	Changing position because they introduced new data or a valid argument
Destroys credibility	Builds credibility

Hold: “Brand value is real — I’m not dismissing it. But we can’t currently measure it. What I can measure is \$80K generated 3 qualified leads — \$26K per lead vs. our \$3–4K paid benchmark. I’m holding my recommendation.”

Update: “That changes my recommendation. A \$280K renewal risk wasn’t in my analysis. SSO moves to the front of the sprint.”

Key insight: You must know, in the moment, whether you’re caving or updating. They feel similar from the inside.

FRAMEWORK 10 • NEW IN V2

Read Before You Respond

Executive presence is not only what you say — it’s what you understood before you spoke. Research consistently identifies two listening-side traits: a “listen to learn” orientation and the ability to read an audience. Most communication training ignores both.

Move 1 — Ask one question before you advocate

Before making your case in a contested room, surface what you don’t know about their position. This is not softness — it’s reconnaissance.

“Before I give you my view — what’s driving the concern on your side? I want to make sure I’m solving the right problem.”

Move 2 — Reframe for the audience

Same recommendation, different lead. Lead with what they optimise for.

Audience	They optimise for	Lead with
CFO	Cost, risk, predictability	The number and the downside protection
CEO	Strategy, speed, market position	The strategic bet and what it unlocks
Engineering	Feasibility, technical debt	The constraint and what you're protecting
Sales	Pipeline, timing, competition	The customer impact and the timeline
Your team	Workload, priority, meaning	What changes for them and what you're removing

Same recommendation — “pause feature work for one sprint”:

To the CFO: *“Two weeks of debt work now avoids an estimated 8–10 weeks of reactive cost next quarter.”*

To the CEO: *“We're one incident away from an enterprise churn event. This protects the segment we're betting on.”*

To the team: *“I'm clearing the roadmap for two weeks so you can fix what's been bothering you. Nothing new gets added.”*

Move 3 — Name what you heard before you counter

Before disagreeing, prove you understood. Two effects: you're demonstrably listening, and you often discover you misread the objection.

“So the concern is that pausing features signals to customers that we're slowing down. Is that the core worry, or is there more?”

Key insight: The most senior person in the room is often the one asking the sharpest question, not giving the longest answer.

PART FOUR

Embodiment

How you deliver, and what compounds over time

FRAMEWORK 11 • NEW IN V2

The Pause Principle

The best-structured argument, delivered at speed with rising intonation and no pauses, still reads as junior. Delivery is not decoration — it is a signal about how much you trust your own content.

Habit	What it does
Pause before answering	Two seconds of silence signals consideration. “So, um, that’s a great question...” signals you’re buying time.
Pause after your recommendation	Say it. Then stop. Rushing to justify is the most common tell of low confidence.
Land your sentences	Upward inflection turns a statement into a question. “We should ship Friday?” ≠ “We should ship Friday.”
Slow down as stakes rise	The default under pressure is to speed up. Drop your pace ~20%. It reads as control.

Quick self-audit

Tell	Fix
“So, um...” before answering	Pause instead. Silence beats filler.
Justifying immediately after your recommendation	Stop talking. Let it land.
Statements ending in upward pitch	Land the sentence. Drop the tone.
Speaking faster when challenged	Deliberately slow to ~80% of normal pace.
Trailing off at the end of a point	Finish the sentence fully, then stop.

Key insight: How you deliver is a claim about how much you believe what you’re saying. Rushed delivery undermines even a perfect argument.

FRAMEWORK 12 • NEW IN V2

The Consistency Compound

Research separates two categories of perception: **short-term impressions** (appearance, confidence, communication style — assessed in seconds) and **long-term evaluations** (interpersonal integrity, values in action, outcome delivery ability — built over months).

Frameworks 1–11 optimise for the moment. This one optimises for the accumulation. It is the only framework you cannot practise in a single session — and it outweighs all the others combined.

Behaviour	What it means in practice
Outcome delivery	Every “I’ll get back to you by Thursday” is a credibility contract. Kept, it compounds. Broken, it discounts everything you say afterwards. Only commit to timelines you’d bet money on.
Values in action	People judge your values by your behaviour when holding them costs you something. Do you credit the team when you presented the win? Do you give the honest recommendation when it’s unpopular?
Consistency across audiences	Whether you say the same thing to your team, your manager, and your peers. Presence collapses fast when people compare notes and find three versions of your position.

The quarterly check

1. What did I commit to this quarter, and did I deliver it?
2. Where did my stated values and my actual behaviour diverge?
3. Would my team, manager, and peers describe my position on [key issue] the same way?
4. What did I get wrong, and did I say so out loud?

Key insight: Executive presence built on delivery compounds. Executive presence built only on communication style depreciates the moment someone checks your track record.

Quick Reference

#	Framework	When to use	Core rule
1	BLUF	Any written or verbal update	Answer first, explain second
2	Minto Pyramid	Emails, briefs, structured arguments	Governing answer → MECE arguments → data
3	C·D·S	Status updates, proposals	Claim + Data + So what
4	PMI	Decisions, trade-off analysis	Plus / Minus / Interesting → recommend
5	SCR	Meeting openings, exec summaries	Situation → Complication → Resolution
6	Story Structure	All-hands, investor updates	Hook → Context → Insight → CTA
7	Decisive Answering	Any direct question	Yes / No / I'll find out by [time]
8	Meeting Lead	Opening any meeting	Decide, not discuss — stance in 3 sentences
9	A·D·A	Any pushback or challenge	Acknowledge → Data → Affirm or Adjust
10	Read Before You Respond	Contested rooms, cross-functional	Ask first · Reframe for audience · Name what you heard
11	Pause Principle	Every spoken interaction	Pause before · Pause after · Land it · Slow down
12	Consistency Compound	Ongoing, across quarters	Deliver what you committed. Same position to every audience.

The through-line: Use **PMI** to think → **Minto** to structure → **SCR** to open → **C·D·S** to anchor every claim → **Read Before You Respond** to understand the room → **Decisive Answering** for questions → **A·D·A** for challenges → **Meeting Lead** to run the room → **Story Structure** to make it stick → **Pause Principle** to deliver it → and let the **Consistency Compound** do the work no single conversation can.

Executive presence is not a personality trait. It is a set of practised habits — and the ones that compound matter more than the ones that impress.

Sources informing v2

Barbara Minto, *The Pyramid Principle* · Edward de Bono, PMI thinking tool · Sylvia Ann Hewlett, “The New Rules of Executive Presence,” *Harvard Business Review* (2024) · Dagley & Gaskin, “Understanding Executive Presence,” *Consulting Psychology Journal* 66(3) (2014) · Chilcutt & DuPont, *The Presence Principle* (2026) · MIT Sloan Executive Education (2026) · IMD (2026)